FOR PARENTS · SUPPORTING YOUR YOUNG PLAYER

FRIENDSHIPS & TEAM DYNAMICS

Cliques, new kids and falling out with teammates

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THE QUICK VERSION

> For many young players, friendships are the main reason they love their team, and the main reason they leave. Helping your child navigate team relationships, including the tricky ones, builds skills they'll use in every team they're ever part of.

WHAT'S REALLY GOING ON

Teams are small communities. There will be cliques, disagreements, new players and friends who move on. Most friendship ups and downs are normal and can be worked through with a bit of support and perspective. But exclusion, bullying or meanness that keeps happening needs adult help.

COMMON SITUATIONS AND HOW TO HELP

BEING THE NEW KID

Arrive a few minutes early, help them say hi to one teammate, and suggest a catch-up outside training.

FEELING LEFT OUT

Listen first. Help them find one or two teammates to connect with, rather than the whole group.

FALLING OUT WITH A FRIEND

Help them think about the other side and how to fix it. Most fall-outs blow over.

BULLYING OR MEANNESS

If it keeps happening, it isn't normal friendship drama. Speak to the coach or club welfare officer.

Be the teammate you'd want

Encourage your child to look out for the new player, include the quiet one and celebrate when others do well. Kind teammates create kind teams, and they're remembered long after the scores are forgotten.

TRY THIS

1. **Ask about the team, not just the game**
   "Who did you sit with?" "Who made you laugh today?"
2. **Help organise a team catch-up**
   A park kick or a pizza night helps friendships grow off the pitch.
3. **Don't take over**
   Help your child solve small problems themselves before stepping in.
4. **Stay out of parent politics**
   Avoid gossiping about other players or families.
5. **Act on bullying**
   If your child is being excluded or hurt repeatedly, talk to the club straight away.

SAY THIS, NOT THAT

SAY THIS	NOT THAT
"How do you think she felt about it?"	~~"Just ignore them, they're not worth it."~~
"Who could you get to know better?"	~~"You don't need friends, just play."~~
"Let's talk to the coach about this together."	~~"That's just how girls (or boys) are."~~

QUICK SELF-CHECK

- [ ] I know who my child's friends on the team are
- [ ] I ask about the social side of training
- [ ] I let them solve small issues first
- [ ] I know who to contact if bullying happens

Can't tick them all yet? That's normal. Pick one to work on this week.

COACH'S CORNER

> **The friendships you make in a team can last a lifetime. Many players say their closest friends are people they met kicking a ball as kids.**

THE FUTURE BALLER TEAM